

LODGE LEADERSHIP GUIDE

Ancient Order of Free Gardeners, Inc.

For Constituent & Independent Lodges Updated to Include Mandatory Reporting Requirements

I. Lodge Officer Responsibilities

1. Worthy Master

The Worthy Master is the chief executive officer of the Lodge.

Responsibilities:

- Preside over all Lodge meetings and maintain order.
- Represent the Lodge publicly and ceremonially.
- Appoint officers and committee chairs.
- Ensure Lodge compliance with:
 - AOfG Constitution & By-Laws
 - Grand Lodge By-Laws
 - Lodge By-Laws
 - Ceremonial standards
- Approve regalia use at public events.
- Oversee discipline, decorum, and ceremony integrity.

2. Emissary Master

Deputy executive officer.

Responsibilities:

- Assist the Worthy Master.
- Preside in the Worthy Master's absence.
- Represent the Lodge during visitations.
- Carry out assignments from the Worthy Master.

3. Secretary

The Secretary is the administrative and record-keeping officer.

Responsibilities:

- Maintain all Lodge correspondence.
- Prepare meeting agendas with the Worthy Master.

- Record accurate minutes of all Lodge meetings.
- Maintain Lodge membership database and Database.
- Collect and archive committee reports.
- Complete and submit:
 - **Annual Reports**
 - **Admission Records**
- Submit all required documents to:
 - **Grand Lodge (if applicable)**
 - **United Council (always required)**
- Maintain ceremonial and administrative archives.

4. Rentmaster

Financial officer.

Responsibilities:

- Receive, safeguard, and disburse Lodge funds.
- Maintain accurate ledgers and financial statements.
- Present financial reports at regular meetings.
- Coordinate with the Financial Oversight Committee.
- Support audits and fundraising.

5. Instruction Master

Ceremonial and educational officer.

Responsibilities:

- Ensure accuracy and uniformity in ceremonial work.
- Train officers and members in ceremony procedures.
- Chair the Ceremonial Standards Committee.
- Conduct workshops and instructional sessions.

6. Chaplain

Spiritual support officer.

Responsibilities:

- Provide invocations and benedictions.
- Support members during hardship or bereavement.
- Uphold the moral values of the Order.

7. Gatekeeper & Keyholder

Ceremonial security officers.

Gatekeeper Responsibilities:

- Guard the outer door.
- Ensure only qualified members enter.
- Maintain ceremonial environment.

Keyholder Responsibilities:

- Guard the inner door.
- Escort dignitaries and visitors.
- Arrange regalia and officer placement.

II. Handling Inquiries & Applications

1. Responding to Initial Inquiries

Use the **Interest Email Template** to:

- Introduce AOFG history and mission.
- Clarify differences between global branches.
- Direct seekers to AOFG website and social media.
- Provide the membership application.
- Invite questions.

2. Acknowledging Application Receipt

Send the **Application Receipt Email**:

- Confirm receipt.
- Inform seeker that a member will contact them within **7–10 business days**.
- Provide Lodge contact information.

3. Reviewing Applications

Lodge officers should:

1. Review application for completeness.
2. Conduct an interview or introductory conversation.
3. Present application at a Lodge meeting.
4. Vote according to Lodge By-Laws.
5. Record decision in the minutes.

4. Approval Notification

Send the **Approval Letter**:

- Congratulate the seeker.
- Affirm acceptance.
- Inform them that ceremony details will follow.
- Maintain ceremonial tone.

5. Scheduling Degree Ceremonies

Use the **Admission Record** to document:

- Ceremony date and location
- Degrees conferred
- Officers present
- Number of members present
- Full seeker information

This form becomes part of the Lodge's permanent records **and must be submitted**.

III. Record Keeping Requirements

Lodges must maintain accurate records of all administrative, ceremonial, and financial activity.

Required Records:

- Membership Database and database
- Meeting minutes
- Degree and ceremony records
- Financial ledgers and statements
- Committee reports
- Officer information
- Annual summaries

These records must be available for review by the Grand Lodge (if any) and the United Council.

IV. Completing & Submitting Reports

(Updated to include mandatory submission requirements)

1. Annual Report — Mandatory Submission

The Annual Report includes:

- Lodge information
- Meeting schedule

- New initiates
- Members deceased
- Members in good standing
- Rank totals
- Annual summary
- Officer Database
- Updated Lodge database

Submission Requirements: The **Secretary** must submit the completed Annual Report to:

1. **Grand Lodge** (if applicable)
2. **United Council** (always required)

Signed by:

- Worthy Master
- Secretary

2. Admission Record — Mandatory Submission

The Admission Record includes:

- Lodge and officer information
- Ceremony details
- Degrees conferred
- Seeker information
- Signatures of Worthy Master and Secretary

Submission Requirements: The **Secretary** must submit each Admission Record to:

1. **Grand Lodge** (if applicable)
2. **United Council** (always required)**

A copy must be retained in Lodge archives.

3. Committee Reports

Committee chairs must submit written reports to the Secretary for inclusion in minutes and transmission when requested.

4. Financial Reports

Rentmaster presents financial statements at regular meetings and ensures records are available for audit.

V. Lodge Meeting Requirements

Regular Meetings

- Must be announced 30 days in advance.
- Reminder sent 7 days before.

Quorum

- Minimum of **four active members**.

Agenda Requirements

- Secretary issues agenda and documentation 3 days before.

Lodge Room Procedures

- The Keepers shall be responsible for setting up the lodge room in accordance with the ceremonies of the Order.
- The Worthy Master will instruct the Gatekeeper to open the door and inform the members that they may enter.
- Appropriate music is played as the members enter (preferably Scottish pipes and drums)
- Officers should familiarize themselves with the opening and closing ceremonies before meetings.

VI. Lodge Committees

Standing committees include:

- Ceremonial Standards
- Growth & Expansion
- Preservation & Instruction
- Public Relations & Communications
- Financial Oversight

Each committee must maintain minutes and submit reports.

VII. Summary: Lodge Leadership Workflow

Monthly / Meeting Cycle

- Notice + agenda issued
- Worthy Master presides
- Officers deliver reports

- Committees deliver reports
- Applications reviewed
- Minutes recorded

Annual Cycle

- Annual Planning Meeting
- Annual Report submitted
- Officer elections
- Installation ceremony
- Database update submitted

Membership Cycle

- Inquiry → Interest Email
- Application → Receipt Email
- Review → Vote
- Approval → Approval Letter
- Ceremony → Admission Record
- Database update → Annual Report

Mandatory Submissions

Secretary must submit:

- Annual Reports → Grand Lodge + United Council
- Admission Records → Grand Lodge + United Council